



PAC-12 PREVIEW



MADDUX MADSEN AND DYLAN RILEY, BOISE STATE



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH



1

**BOISE STATE
BRONCOS**



2

**SAN DIEGO STATE
AZTECS**



3

**FRESNO STATE
BULLDOGS**



4

**WASHINGTON STATE
COUGARS**



5

**UTAH STATE
AGGIES**



6

**TEXAS STATE
BOBCATS**



7

**COLORADO STATE
RAMS**



8

**OREGON STATE
BEAVERS**

PAC-12 CHAMPIONSHIP

BOISE ST. OVER SAN DIEGO ST.



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT ATHLONSPORTS.COM FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-PAC-12 TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	MADDUX MADSEN	Boise State
RB	LUCKY SUTTON	San Diego State
RB	DYLAN RILEY	Boise State
AP	SIRE GAINES	Boise State
WR	JORDAN NAPIER	San Diego State
WR	CHRIS DAWN JR.	Texas State
WR	BEAU SPARKS	Texas State
TE	JUICE VEREEN	Colorado State
C	JIMMY LISTON	Utah State
OL	ROGER CARREON	Boise State
OL	JOSEPH BORJON	San Diego State
OL	ASHTON TRIPP	Washington State
OL	BRAYDEN WALTON	Fresno State

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	JAYDEN VIRGIN-MORGAN	Boise State
DL	MAX STEGE	Boise State
DL	DEIJON LAFFITTE	Fresno State
DL	TYREE MORRIS	Utah State
LB	TANO LETULI	San Diego State
LB	BRONSON OLEVAO JR.	Utah State
LB	AIDEN SULLIVAN	Oregon State
LB	BOEN PHELPS	Boise State
CB	SIMEON HARRIS	Fresno State
CB	JADEN MICKEY	Boise State
S	DALESEAN STALEY	San Diego State
S	BREVIN HAMBLIN	Utah State

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	COLTON BOOMER	Boise State
P	OSCAR DOYLE	Boise State
KR	JAYLEN JENKINS	Texas State
PR	TONY FREEMAN	Washington State

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Poinsettia: San Diego State vs. UNLV

Xbox: Utah State vs. Old Dominion

Puerto Rico: Fresno State vs. South Florida

First Responder: Washington State vs. Cal

College Football Playoff First Round: Boise State vs. Indiana

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

BOISE STATE

Offense: New: Nate Potter, Zak Hill
Old: Nate Potter

Defense: New: Terence Brown, Erik Chinander; Old: Erik Chinander

COLORADO STATE

Offense: New: Pryce Tracy
Old: Matt Mumme, Bill Best

Defense: New: Tyson Summers, Kenny McClendon; Old: Tyson Summers

OREGON STATE

Offense: New: Mitch Dahlen, Ryan Wallace; Old: Ryan Gunderson

Defense: New: Mike MacIntyre, Cort Dennison; Old: Rod Chance and Ilaisa Tuiaki

SAN DIEGO STATE

Defense: New: Demetrius Sumler
Old: Rob Aurich

TEXAS STATE

Offense: New: Landon Keopple, Jordan Shoemaker; Old: Landon Keopple

Defense: New: Will Windham, Matthew Gregg; Old: Dexter McCoil Sr., Bradley Dale Peveto

UTAH STATE

Offense: New: Robert Anae
Old: Kevin McGiven

WASHINGTON STATE

Offense: New: Matt Miller
Old: Danny Freund

Defense: New: Trent Bray
Old: Jesse Bobbit



TRENT BRAY, WASHINGTON STATE

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Terrious Favors	WR	Boise State	★★★	447
2. La'Keyleon Graves	ATH	Texas State	★★★	613
3. Xavier Warren	WR	Texas State	★★★	686
4. Kole Cronin	OT	Boise State	★★★	700
5. Cynai Thomas	WR	Oregon State	★★★	726



BEAU SPARKS, TEXAS STATE
TANO LETULLI, SAN DIEGO STATE



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. Caden Pinnick	QB	Washington State	UC Davis
Pinnick's passing efficiency earned him FCS All-America honors.			
2. McCae Hillstead	QB	Utah State	BYU
Hillstead flashed for the Aggies across four starts back in 2023.			
3. Hauss Hejny	QB	Colorado State	Oklahoma State
Hejny is a former blue-chip recruit who showed promise for the Cowboys.			
4. Roman Tillmon	S	Boise State	South Dakota
Tillmon fills an area of need, and he's a willing and capable tackler.			
5. JeRico Washington Jr.	CB	Boise State	Kennesaw State
Washington is a playmaker who forced 10 turnovers for the Owls.			
6. Antonio Bluiett	DB	Utah State	North Dakota
FCS All-American brings ample experience to the Aggies' secondary.			
7. Khristian Martin	QB	Fresno State	Maryland
Martin's arm strength and mobility should open up the Bulldogs' offense.			
8. Harrison Taggart	LB	Utah State	Cal
Taggart brings Power 4 experience to the heart of the Aggies' defense.			
9. Xayvion Noland	WR	Oregon State	UTRGV
Noland stretched the field in the FCS, averaging 21 yards per catch in '25.			
10. Juice Vereen	TE	Colorado State	UConn
Vereen broke out as a big-play threat for the Huskies last season.			

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. Boise State (53)	4. Texas State (76)	7. Oregon State (109)
2. Fresno State (68)	5. San Diego State (86)	8. Washington State (131)
3. Colorado State (72)	6. Utah State (87)	

Rankings per Rivals;
National ranking in parentheses

GAMES TO WATCH

Sept. 5 Boise State at Oregon	Oct. 10 Boise State at Fresno State
Sept. 5 Washington State at Washington	Oct. 17 Fresno State at San Diego St.
Sept. 5 Wyoming at Colorado State	Oct. 17 Washington State at Oregon St.
Sept. 12 Memphis at Boise State	Nov. 7 Fresno State at Utah State
Sept. 19 Utah State at Utah	Nov. 14 Fresno State at Texas State
Sept. 19 James Madison at San Diego St.	Nov. 21 San Diego State at Boise State

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Cullen Thompson	EDGE	Texas State	★★★	753
7. Jameson Powell	WR	Oregon State	★★★	768
8. Isaiah Lucero	CB	Fresno State	★★★	807
9. Derek Stevenson	WR	San Diego State	★★★	819
10. Keilan Chavies	RB	Boise State	★★★	841

Rankings per Rivals industry ranking



BOISE STATE BRONCOS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 24 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 9-5, 6-2 MWC

OFFENSE Redshirt senior quarterback Maddux Madsen is heading into his third season as Boise State’s starter, and he’ll be working with a relatively fresh-faced receiving corps and offensive line.

The Broncos lost their top four pass-catchers from 2025. However, junior wide receiver Cameron Bates offers both a vertical threat and speed on end-around plays and is expected to step up in 2026. He’ll be assisted by 6-foot-5 tight end Matt Wagner, who has proven to have safe hands over the past two years, recording 34 catches for 359 yards in 27 games.

Boise State returns its two leading running backs in junior Dylan Riley and redshirt sophomore Sire Gaines. The pair combined for 1,977 rushing yards in 2025 and should split the carries in 2026.

DEFENSE The Broncos lost nearly their entire secondary from last season, but former Notre Dame transfer Jaden Mickey is expected to lead the defense at the cornerback and nickel spots in his second year with the program.

The Broncos are also in search of a new linebacker group. Redshirt junior Boen Phelps offers great speed and coverage at the position, but tackling could remain an issue — missed tackles at both the first and second levels proved costly in 2025.

Sack production dropped from 55 in 2024 to 27 in 2025, but that stat will likely jump back up in 2026. The Broncos return upperclassman edge rushers Max Stege and Jayden Virgin-Morgan, the latter of whom led Boise State last season in tackles for a loss (13) and sacks (six).

SPECIALISTS Special teams were a sore point for Boise State last year; however, the Broncos will have consistency with the return of place-kicker Colton Boomer and punter Oscar Doyle. Boomer hit all three of his attempts from 50-plus yards and has been bullish about his accuracy improvements. The main issue in 2025 was a lack of explosiveness in the return game. Speedy receivers Bates, Quinton Brown and Terrious Favors are among the favorites to handle punt and kickoff returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS Boise State enters the reborn Pac-12 as the rightful favorite, but the question is, how far can the Broncos go? Madsen has proven his capabilities against Group of 6 opponents, but he has gone 0-4 against Power 4 opponents. Breaking that streak against either Oregon in Week 1 or in the postseason would go a long way for the Broncos.

If Boise State can consistently get its run game going to help open the pass game for an experienced QB, an inaugural Pac-12 title and a shot at the College Football Playoff are certainly on the table in 2026.

2025 RESULTS (9-5, 6-2 MWC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	at South Florida	L	7-34	Sept. 5	at Oregon	1. Davin Hill, CB	★★★
Sept. 5	Eastern Washington	W	51-14	Sept. 12	Memphis	2. Terrious Favors, WR	★★★
Sept. 20	at Air Force	W	49-37	Sept. 19	South Dakota	3. Rasean Jones, WR	★★★
Sept. 27	Appalachian State	W	47-14	Sept. 26	at W. Michigan	4. Akeem Wright, WR	★★★
Oct. 4	at Notre Dame	L	7-28	Oct. 3	Utah State	5. Keilan Chavies, RB	★★★
Oct. 11	New Mexico	W	41-25	Oct. 10	at Fresno State	6. Keawe Browne, TE	★★★
Oct. 18	UNLV	W	56-31	Oct. 24	at Washington St.	7. Paz St John, DL	★★★
Oct. 24	at Nevada	W	24-3	Oct. 31	Texas State	8. Adam Auston, LB	★★★
Nov. 1	Fresno State	L	7-30	Nov. 7	at Colorado State	9. Jackson Taylor, QB	★★★
Nov. 15	at San Diego State	L	7-17	Nov. 14	Oregon State	10. Ryan Brekke, TE	★★★
Nov. 22	Colorado State	W	49-21	Nov. 21	San Diego State		
Nov. 28	at Utah State	W	25-24	Nov. 28	at Utah State #		
Dec. 5	UNLV #	W	38-21	#Projected Flex Opponent			*Per Rivals
Dec. 13	vs. Washington %	L	10-38	TEAM INFORMATION			
#MW Championship %LA Bowl				Head Coach: Spencer Danielson • Record at School: 24-8 (2+ years) Career Record: 24-8 (2+ years) • Offensive Coordinators: Nate Potter, Zak Hill Defensive Coordinators: Terence Brown, Erik Chinander • Location: Boise, Idaho • Stadium: Albertsons Stadium (36,387)			



SCOUTING THE BRONCOS

“Their record over the last couple years speaks for itself as far as being the team to watch in the Pac-12. I probably study them the most out of all the teams in the conference. I’m really curious to see how they play up front on both sides of the ball because I know that they lost a couple of players there. Their quarterback [Maddux Madsen] got experience that only helped him last year. I’m sure he’ll be a lot better this year than he was last year, and so will their passing game as a whole. ... They’re super athletic from sideline to sideline. They’re gonna be really good. I just think that continuity at the quarterback position and in the passing game is gonna be massive for them. I’m just curious to see how they play up front.”

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART			
OFFENSE (7)			
WR	13	Darren Morris* (Sr.)	19 Rasean Jones (Fr.)
WR	80	CAMERON BATES (JR.)	85 Terrious Favors (Fr.)
WR	82	Ben Ford (Sr.)	21 Akeem Wright* (Sr.)
LT	70	Kyle Cox (Jr.)	78 Tyler Ethridge* (Sr.)
LG	64	Carson Rasmussen (Jr.)	52 Stewart Taufa (Fr.)
C	67	JASON STEELE (JR.)	69 Zander Esty* (Jr.)
RG	62	ROGER CARREON (SR.)	68 Jake Steele (Sr.)
RT	75	DAYLON METOYER (SR.)	66 Jacob Tracy (Fr.)
TE	88	MATT WAGNER (JR.)	86 Austin Terry (Sr.)
QB	4	MADDUX MADSEN (SR.)	10 Cash Herrera (Fr.)
RB	24	DYLAN RILEY (JR.)	26 Sire Gaines (So.)
DEFENSE (4)			
DE	95	MAX STEGE (SR.)	51 Roman Caywood (So.)
NT	92	David Latu (Sr.)	96 Lopez Sanusi (So.)
DT	99	Michael Madrie (Jr.)	97 Mikaio Edward* (Jr.)
EDGE	5	JAYDEN VIRGIN-MORGAN (SR.)	91 Bol Bol (So.)
ILB	43	Jake Ripp (Sr.)	44 Syncere Brackett-Lambey (So.)
OLB	1	BOEN PHELPS (JR.)	17 Logan Brantley (Jr.)
CB	8	Sherrod Smith (Jr.)	16 Franklyn Johnson Jr. (Jr.)
CB	14	Demetrius Freeny Jr. (Sr.)	15 JeRico Washington Jr.* (Jr.)
NB	7	Jaden Mickey (Sr.)	38 Travis Anderson (So.)
S	10	DEREK GANTER JR. (JR.)	20 Kyle Hall* (Jr.)
SS	22	Roman Tillmon* (Jr.)	33 Josiah Alanis (Fr.)
SPECIALISTS			
K	35	Colton Boomer (Sr.)	KR 80 Cameron Bates (Jr.)
P	37	Oscar Doyle (Sr.)	PR 25 Quinton Brown (So.)



TOMMY MAHER

SCOUTING THE RAMS

"[Former UConn head coach] Jim L. Mora was a great hire. He's an excellent coach. He's done it on every level, and I think he'll do a great job of building Colorado State into an excellent team. There's no doubt in my mind that he can do that. ... They're such an unknown in our league. Normally when guys follow from one staff to another — like Iowa State to Penn State, or Curt Cignetti with JMU to Indiana — you can get a sense of what those teams are gonna be. But UConn was an independent who played everybody. They were a good team with a lot of Northeast guys. I don't get the sense that it's just going to automatically follow with them playing the exact same way."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	9	Jordan Mosley* (Sr.)	0	RJ Vick* (Sr.)
WR	15	Terrence Smith Jr.* (So.)	4	Lavon Brown (Jr.)
WR	10	TOMMY MAHER (JR.)	6	Jackson Harper* (Jr.)
LT	76	Toriyan Johnson* (Jr.)	63	John Holthaus (So.)
LG	61	Diego Rodriguez* (So.)	74	Payton Stewart* (So.)
C	65	Phillip Ocon (So.)	73	Braden Hales (So.)
RG	50	Jayden Tuia* (So.)	70	Berlin Lillard (So.)
RT	54	Quinton Harris* (Sr.)	71	Zach Smith (So.)
TE	5	Juice Vereen* (Jr.)	30	Dominic Toy* (So.)
QB	8	Hauss Hejny* (Fr.)	2	K'saan Farrar* (Fr.)
RB	1	Mel Brown* (Sr.)	11	Durrell Robinson* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DL	95	Gabe Jones (Jr.)	94	Alton Tarber IV (Sr.)
DL	93	Robby Harrison* (Sr.)	97	Amare Bell (Fr.)
DL	96	Brandon Kelley* (Jr.)	77	JACK MORAN (SO.)
DL	92	MUKENDI WA-KALONJI (SR.)	52	Cleto Chol* (Jr.)
LB	2	Oumar Diomande* (Jr.)	56	KENYON AGURS (JR.)
LB	23	Jaseim Mitchell (Sr.)	27	Jaylen King (Fr.)
LB	8	Antarron Turner* (Sr.)	28	Marc Pretto* (Sr.)
CB	0	Caleb Presley* (Jr.)	1	Richard Mosley III* (Jr.)
CB	17	CJ Blocker (Jr.)	4	Dylan Phelps (Jr.)
S	13	Elijah Mc-Cantos* (Sr.)	12	JACE BELLAH (SR.)
S	15	Tre'Shawn Moore* (Jr.)	18	AJ Noland (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	40	Kali Nguma* (Jr.)	KR	1	Mel Brown* (Sr.)
P	99	Cavan Craig* (So.)	PR	15	Terrence Smith Jr.* (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



COLORADO STATE RAMS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 97 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 2-10, 1-7 MWC

OFFENSE Offensive coordinator Pryce Tracy, former UConn passing game coordinator and quarterbacks coach, gets his first chance as a play-caller, as he hopes to bring the explosive 2025 UConn offense to Colorado State. The Rams plan to be a dangerous outside-zone run team with a lot of good backs. Tight ends will be a feature in the pass game.

The biggest question is at quarterback, where Oklahoma State transfer Hauss Hejny and UConn transfer K'saan Farrar are in a real battle for the No. 1 spot. Both are inexperienced at the college level, but both are also talented. Hejny is a former 4-star recruit who is lightning quick and a dangerous runner. Farrar also has good running ability and a strong arm. In this offense, dual-threat ability will be a necessity.

The offensive line is rebuilt as well. A couple of returning wide receivers (Tommy Maher and Lavon Brown) will pair with a bunch of newcomers who provide a lot of options but no clear No. 1 yet.

DEFENSE New head coach Jim L. Mora retained Tyson Summers as defensive coordinator (with Kenny McClendon joining as co-DC). Summers served as interim CSU head coach following the midseason firing of Jay Norvell. Summers' defense is built on aggressive, attacking play, but injuries prevented the Rams from realizing that vision last season. Newcomer Oumar Diomande, a linebacker, followed Mora from UConn and should be a centerpiece of the defense.

After CSU finished last season with virtually no healthy defensive linemen, this year's group should be bigger (both in terms of numbers and overall size). There are questions at cornerback due to some spring injuries. Appalachian State transfer Elijah Mc-Cantos will be a key back-end piece at safety. If the Rams are to see significant improvement, Summers' defense must be at or near the top of the Pac-12 in turnovers forced.

SPECIALISTS The special teams unit looks brand-new as well. CSU struggled in the kicking game last season, but North Texas transfer Kali Nguma should help clean that up. UConn transfer running back Mel Brown could be a dangerous kickoff returner.

FINAL ANALYSIS It's a season of change. Mora will try to unlock the potential he envisions at CSU; he has talked about championships from Day 1. The Rams are also changing leagues, beginning play in the new Pac-12.

Mora turned UConn around, creating hope that he could do the same in Fort Collins for a program that has underachieved for years. In addition to a revamped coaching staff, there are more than 60 new players at CSU, including several who followed Mora from UConn. There's a lot that's new, but the win-now urgency feels familiar.

2025 RESULTS (2-10, 1-7 MWC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at Washington	L	21-38	Sept. 5	Wyoming	1. Jaylen King, LB	★★★★
Sept. 6	Northern Colorado	W	21-17	Sept. 12	Southern Utah	2. Kallen Martinez, CB	★★★★
Sept. 20	UTSA	L	16-17	Sept. 19	BYU	3. Justin Lewis, CB	★★★★
Sept. 27	Washington State	L	3-20	Sept. 26	at UTSA	4. Jermaine Santana-Diaz, S	★★★★
Oct. 3	at San Diego State	L	24-45	Oct. 3	Oregon State	5. Cedric Ross, WR	★★★★
Oct. 10	Fresno State	W	49-21	Oct. 17	at Texas State	6. Troy Foster, WR	★★★★
Oct. 18	Hawai'i	L	19-31	Oct. 24	San Diego State	7. Darnell Kelly, QB	★★★★
Oct. 25	at Wyoming	L	0-28	Oct. 31	at Utah State	8. Max Vivier, OT	★★★★
Nov. 8	UNLV	L	10-42	Nov. 7	Boise State	9. Damian Moore Jr., RB	★★★★
Nov. 15	at New Mexico	L	17-20	Nov. 14	at Washington St.	10. Mickey Williams, EDGE	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Boise State	L	21-49	Nov. 21	at Fresno State		
Nov. 28	Air Force	L	21-42	Nov. 28	Texas State #		
				#Projected Flex Opponent		*Per Rivals	

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Jim L. Mora • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: 73-53 (10 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Pryce Tracy
Defensive Coordinators: Tyson Summers, Kenny McClendon • Location: Fort Collins, Colo. • Stadium: Canvas Stadium (36,500)



FRESNO STATE BULLDOGS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 68 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 5-3 MWC

OFFENSE The Bulldogs lack experience at the quarterback position — the five players who took snaps in spring ball have played a total of 82 snaps at the FBS level. Khristian Martin and Jayden Mandal were the top two contenders, and both add a run-game element that head coach Matt Entz says the Bulldogs will utilize this season. Both also have the arm strength to push the football down the field, something the Bulldogs did very rarely last season. Martin, a transfer from Maryland, appears to be the front-runner to win the job.

The Bulldogs return their top three running backs in Rayshon Luke, Bryson Donelson and Brandon Ramirez as well as their top three wide-outs in Josiah Freeman, Ezekiel Avit and Jahlil McClain.

DEFENSE Fresno State was able to retain defensive coordinator Nick Benedetto and his staff after a stellar first season in the San Joaquin Valley. That's a big plus for the Bulldogs, who allowed only 285.7 yards per game, ranking first in the Mountain West Conference and 10th in the nation. They also were second in the nation in passing defense (153.8 ypg), tied for fourth in fewest plays of 20 or more yards allowed (36), fifth in interceptions (20) and 16th in scoring defense (18.8 ppg). They did that without a single player on the all-conference first team and only two on the second team.

The Bulldogs have potential standouts returning, including nickel Simeon Harris and linebackers K'vion Thunderbird and Tytus Khajavi, and this unit should continue to play at a high level. Similar numbers this season should result in more all-conference recognition.

SPECIALISTS Fresno State has one of the best special teams coaches in the country in John Baxter. Last season, the Bulldogs led the Mountain West in opponent kickoff and punt returns, allowing just 16.1 and 3.0 yards per return, respectively. Punter Nick Verdugo returns, but the Bulldogs have to replace kicker Dylan Lynch.

FINAL ANALYSIS Fresno State will be an improved team in Entz's second season, but will those gains outpace a schedule that will be more difficult than a year ago? The Bulldogs went 9-4 in 2025 and beat Miami (Ohio) in the Snoop Dogg Arizona Bowl, but their win total included victories over FCS Southern, Oregon State, Nevada, Wyoming and San José State, teams that went a combined 14-46.

To meet the challenge of a tougher schedule, expect a more diverse and dynamic offense that should have the Bulldogs in conference title contention and in a bowl for a sixth year in a row.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 5-3 MWC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 23 at Kansas L 7-31	Sept. 5 at USC	1. Jhadis Luckey, RB ★★★★★
Aug. 30 Georgia Southern W 42-14	Sept. 12 Sacramento State	2. Isaiah Lucero, CB ★★★★★
Sept. 6 at Oregon State W 36-27	Sept. 19 at San José State	3. Deagan Rose, QB ★★★
Sept. 13 Southern W 56-7	Sept. 26 Rice	4. Jake Plummer, EDGE ★★★
Sept. 20 at Hawai'i W 23-21	Oct. 3 at Washington St.	5. Jaydon Sutko, LB ★★★
Oct. 4 Nevada W 20-17	Oct. 10 Boise State	6. Alex Rivera, IOL ★★★
Oct. 10 at Colorado State L 21-49	Oct. 17 at San Diego State	7. Solomon Baker, EDGE ★★★
Oct. 25 San Diego State L 0-23	Oct. 31 Oregon State	8. Xavier Owens, WR ★★★
Nov. 1 at Boise State W 30-7	Nov. 7 at Utah State	9. Cooper Willoughby, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 15 Wyoming W 24-3	Nov. 14 at Texas State	10. Jacob Chambers, QB ★★★
Nov. 22 Utah State L 17-28	Nov. 21 Colorado State	
Nov. 29 at San José State W 41-14	Nov. 28 San Diego State #	
Dec. 27 vs. Miami (Ohio) # W 18-3	#Projected Flex Opponent	*Per Rivals
#Arizona Bowl		
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Matt Entz • Record at School: 9-4 (1 year)		
Career Record: 69-15 (6 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Josh Davis		
Defensive Coordinator: Nick Benedetto • Location: Fresno, Calif.		
Stadium: Valley Children's Stadium (40,727)		



SIMEON HARRIS

SCOUTING THE BULLDOGS

"They have great schemes. I think they're coached really well. They got better as the season went on last year. That's coaching. The biggest challenge with them as they transition to the Pac-12 is, can they have the depth to keep building against a bigger conference? When you're a Group of 6 school and you've got three or four big-time games, it's easy to keep your players healthy. But with their roster, can they be more consistent? Can they stay healthy? ... We really got after them. I know they couldn't do much against us. But they did just get better and better. They've got good young linemen ... I think that [head coach] Matt Entz is a great coach. He's a proven winner."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	5	JOSHIA FREEMAN (SR.)	10	Jordan Malau'ulu (So.)
WR	0	EZEKIEL AVIT (JR.)	19	Harold Duval (So.)
WR	1	Jahlil McClain (Jr.)	11	Jayon Farrar (Sr.)
LT	76	BRAYDEN WALTON (SO.)	55	Marquise Thorpe-Taylor (So.)
LG	72	EDWARD FONUA (SR.)	63	Malcolm Polu Jr. (Fr.)
C	69	Oscar Weigel* (So.)	56	Ben Baker (So.)
RG	65	Jonah Leapepetele (Fr.)	73	Marsel Akins (So.)
RT	71	ROLAN FULLWOOD (SR.)	75	Kyson Van Vugt (Sr.)
TE	87	Jake Appleget* (Sr.)	89	Brock Lium (Jr.)
QB	3	Khristian Martin* (So.)	7	Jayden Mandal (Jr.)
RB	2	Rayshon Luke (Sr.)	6	BRYSON DONELSON (JR.)

DEFENSE (6)

DE	6	JAHZON JACKS (SR.)	9	Merhauti Xepera (Sr.)
DT	0	DEIJON LAFFITTE (JR.)	89	Mordecai Hines (Jr.)
DT	8	MARTIN OWUSU (JR.)	56	Jairus Satele (Sr.)
DE	54	Sione Noa (Sr.)	11	Dylan Hampsten* (Jr.)
LB	10	K'VION THUNDERBIRD (JR.)	35	TYTUS KHAJAVI (SO.)
LB	18	Logan Studt (So.)	25	Justin Johnson (Jr.)
CB	31	Kiontre Harris (So.)	19	Preston Okafor* (So.)
CB	7	Loyall Mouzon (So.)	28	Jomarion Briggs (Sr.)
NB	5	SIMEON HARRIS (SR.)	2	Andre Cobb (Sr.)
S	4	Ethan Tierney (Jr.)	36	Tommy Nix (So.)
S	24	Croix Stewart* (Sr.)	20	RJ Regan (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	38	Manaki Watanabe* (So.)	KR	2	Rayshon Luke (Sr.)
P	41	Nick Verdugo (Sr.)	PR	10	Jordan Malau'ulu (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MAALIK MURPHY



OREGON STATE BEAVERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 101 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 2-10

SCOUTING THE BEAVERS

"Their roster doesn't have a lot of continuity. I don't know what it was like with the transition with the new staff, but I thought they let a lot of pretty good players go to comparable teams, which usually doesn't speak well to internal operation with them understanding what they had. That's a huge no-no at this level. You can lose guys to the big dogs, but you can't lose them to teams that you want to beat. They have a little bit of an uphill battle with their talent pool this year. ... [New head coach JaMarcus Shephard] is a heck of a recruiter and a heck of a leader of men. He's a real motivator. That's what you need at a place like that. He's got connections in California and on the West Coast. I think he fits there with what they're trying to do."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	7	Aeryn Hampton* (So.)	0	Aaron Butler* (So.)
WR	4	Xavyion Noland* (Jr.)	12	Jesse Legree (Fr.)
WR	5	Karson Boschma (Sr.)	17	Malachi Durant (So.)
LT	69	Kwan Johnson* (So.)	72	Noah Thomas (Fr.)
LG	78	NATHAN ELU (SR.)	76	Ben Hartman (Jr.)
C	58	Jack Wagner (So.)	56	Carter Guillaume* (So.)
RG	79	TYLER VOLTIN (SR.)	74	Jacob Anderson (Jr.)
RT	50	Teko Shoats* (Jr.)	71	Josiah Timoteo (Jr.)
TE	8	DeCorion Temple* (Sr.)	87	Jackson Bowers (Jr.)
QB	6	MAALIK MURPHY (SR.)	2	Braden Atkinson* (So.)
RB	3	Cornell Hatcher Jr. (So.)	23	AJ Newberry* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	44	TAKARI HICKLE (SR.)	99	Niklas Fisher (Fr.)
NT	59	Tevita Pome'e (Jr.)	62	Jacob Schuster (Sr.)
DT	97	Tyler Bailey* (Jr.)	91	Jaylen Hill (Fr.)
OLB	17	Ish Findlayter* (Jr.)	18	Jarrel Comer* (Jr.)
MLB	1	Dylan Layne* (Sr.)	9	Raesjon Davis (Sr.)
WLB	2	AIDEN SULLIVAN (SR.)	6	Jabari Odoemenem* (Sr.)
CB	4	TJ Crandall (Jr.)	23	Exodus Ayers (So.)
CB	19	TREY GLASPER (SO.)	29	Zephen Walker (Fr.)
NB	8	SAILASA VADRAWALE III (JR.)	36	Drake Vickers (Sr.)
S	0	Harlem Howard (Jr.)	22	Isaiah Houi* (Jr.)
S	7	Kahanu Kalahiki* (So.)	38	Milan Clark (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	28	Caleb Ojeda (Sr.)	KR	4	Xavyion Noland* (Jr.)
P	38	AJ Winsor (Jr.)	PR	4	Xavyion Noland* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

OFFENSE For the first time since 2019, Oregon State has the chance to start the same Week 1 quarterback in back-to-back years. Former 4-star recruit Maalik Murphy has to win the job first, though. First-year head coach JaMarcus Shephard says that Murphy, along with transfers Braden Atkinson (FCS Mercer) and Brady Jones (Western Michigan), are in an open competition for QB1. Shephard said this spring that he didn't intend to name a starter until mid-August, at the earliest.

Whichever of the three wins the job has a bevy of young, unproven weapons around him. Redshirt sophomore running back Cornell Hatcher Jr. looked impressive in limited reps last fall and is the Beavers' leading returner in the backfield. Wide receiver Xavyion Noland had a breakout year at FCS upstart UT Rio Grande Valley last season and looks ready to be a factor in the passing game.

Tackle transfers Teko Shoats and Kwan Johnson played lots of football in 2025 at the FCS level and look to anchor the Beavers' offensive line this fall. Tyler Voltin missed the spring but is a key piece at guard.

DEFENSE Aiden Sullivan, the Beavers' No. 2 tackler last season, and transfer Dylan Layne from FCS Idaho make for an intriguing tandem at linebacker. Cornerback TJ Crandall made noise in the spring after missing 2025 with an injury and looks like a cornerstone of defensive coordinator Mike McIntyre's unit. Cornerback Trey Glasper played as much as anyone during an up-and-down freshman season and, like Sullivan, was a key piece to retain for 2026.

Takari Hickles battled injuries throughout his career until last season and, according to Shephard, was "unblockable" in the spring. Only time will tell whether it's a testament to Hickles' growth or a condemnation of Oregon State's offensive line.

SPECIALISTS Oregon State endured one of the worst (if not the worst) special teams seasons of all time in 2025 after numerous long-snapper injuries. Placekicker Caleb Ojeda and punter AJ Winsor are back for 2026 with a pair of new snappers, Jonathan Zarut and Tug Sanford, brought in.

FINAL ANALYSIS It's hard to perform much worse than Oregon State's 2-10 season a year ago, but Year 1 in the new-look Pac-12 will challenge Shephard's first Beavers team. Physically, the team looked small in the spring, on the defensive line in particular, and had numerous pieces absent with lingering injury issues. With non-conference opponents Houston and Texas Tech leading off the schedule, September may be unkind to Oregon State. The fan base is hungry for the team to get back to where it was in 2023 when it won eight games, but bowl eligibility would be a win in itself.

2025 RESULTS (2-10)

Aug. 30	Cal	L	15-34
Sept. 6	Fresno State	L	27-36
Sept. 13	at Texas Tech	L	14-45
Sept. 20	at Oregon	L	7-41
Sept. 26	Houston (ot)	L	24-27
Oct. 4	at Appalachian State	L	23-27
Oct. 11	Wake Forest	L	14-39
Oct. 18	Lafayette	W	45-13
Nov. 1	Washington State	W	10-7
Nov. 8	Sam Houston	L	17-21
Nov. 15	at Tulsa	L	14-31
Nov. 29	at Washington State	L	8-32

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Houston
Sept. 12	Texas Tech
Sept. 19	Montana
Sept. 26	at UTEP
Oct. 3	at Colorado State
Oct. 10	San Diego State
Oct. 17	Washington State
Oct. 31	at Fresno State
Nov. 7	Texas State
Nov. 14	at Boise State
Nov. 21	Utah State
Nov. 28	at Washington St.#

#Projected Flex Opponent

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Cynai Thomas, WR	★★★
2.	Jarrel Comer, EDGE	★★★
2.	Jameson Powell, WR	★★★
3.	Tre Garrison, RB	★★★
4.	Kai Wheaton, CB	★★★
5.	Jeremiah Brown, LB	★★★
6.	Xander Chisolm, S	★★★
7.	RJ Whitten, S	★★★
8.	Adel Dorr, EDGE	★★★
9.	Jesse Legree, ATH	★★★
10.	Caleb Metzner, EDGE	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: JaMarcus Shephard • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinators: Mitch Dahlen, Ryan Wallace • Defensive Coordinators: Mike McIntyre, Cort Dennison • Location: Corvallis, Ore. • Stadium: Reser Stadium (35,548)



SAN DIEGO STATE AZTECS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 67 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 MWC

OFFENSE Senior Jayden Denegal (143-for-243, 1,807 yards, nine TDs, eight INTs) gives the Aztecs something they haven't often had of late — a returning starting QB. Even better, Denegal is healthy after being bothered by shoulder issues that limited his practice time and required postseason surgery on his left (non-throwing) shoulder.

Senior Lucky Sutton (1,297 yards, 10 TDs) is among the nation's top returning running backs. Colorado State transfer RB Javion Kinnard provides a boost as a receiving threat out of the backfield. Senior backup QB Bert Emanuel Jr. moves to wide receiver to take advantage of his unique skill set. It was evident when he started in the New Mexico Bowl, rushing for 170 yards and two TDs in a quarter and a half. Starting wideouts Jordan Napier and Jacob Bostick both are coming off reconstructive knee surgery, but there's more depth at the position than SDSU has had in more than a decade.

DEFENSE The Aztecs will be hard-pressed to match last year's unit, which ranked sixth nationally in scoring defense (15.4 ppg) and 11th in total defense (293.7 ypg), after losing their top three defenders — edge Trey White to Texas Tech, linebacker Owen Chambliss to Nebraska and cornerback Chris Johnson to the NFL. Transfer Nate Henrich (Div. II Gannon University) is among the candidates they're counting on at edge.

Senior Tano Letuli is a standout linebacker, but he's coming off reconstructive knee surgery. Senior transfer Sione Hala (FCS Weber State) could be another productive 'backer. Senior safety Dalesean Staley is the only returning starter in the secondary.

SPECIALISTS The Aztecs' kicking and punting has been a strong suit for the better part of a decade. But there's uncertainty following the graduation of Gabriel Plascencia, the most accurate placekicker in school history, and the transfer of punter Hunter Green, who left for Washington. Sophomore Nick Clegg assumes the kicking duties, and senior Tashi Dorje, who averaged 50 yards on three punts, will handle the punting chores. The return game should be solid, especially with Napier and Kinnard, who both were All-Mountain West punt returners last season.

FINAL ANALYSIS SDSU moves into the reconstituted Pac-12 on the heels of a massive turnaround in 2025, improving from 3-9 to 9-4. The Aztecs gained more than they lost in the transfer portal, so it's reasonable to believe they could approach nine wins once again — assuming that the offense, which ranked 78th nationally in scoring (26.4 ppg), is more productive with an experienced, healthy QB and more weapons around him.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 MWC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	Stony Brook	W	42-0	Sept. 5	Portland State	1. Derek Stevenson, WR	★★★★
Sept. 6	at Washington State	L	13-36	Sept. 12	at UCLA	2. Josiah Lucas, RB	★★★
Sept. 20	Cal	W	34-0	Sept. 19	James Madison	3. Alijah Lash, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 27	at Northern Illinois	W	6-3	Sept. 26	at Toledo	4. Robby Lavata'i, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 3	Colorado State	W	45-24	Oct. 3	Texas State	5. Jeremiah Lewis, LB	★★★
Oct. 11	at Nevada	W	44-10	Oct. 10	at Oregon State	7. Marshel Sanders, WR	★★★
Oct. 25	at Fresno State	W	23-0	Oct. 17	Fresno State	7. Marshel Sanders, WR	★★★
Nov. 1	Wyoming	W	24-7	Oct. 24	at Colorado State	8. Tainoa Lave, S	★★★
Nov. 8	at Hawai'i	L	6-38	Oct. 31	Washington State	9. Dominic Coelho, DL	★★★
Nov. 15	Boise State	W	17-7	Nov. 14	Utah State	10. Daishawn Davis, WR	★★★
Nov. 22	San José State	W	25-3	Nov. 21	at Boise State		
Nov. 28	at New Mexico (ot)	L	17-23	Nov. 28	at Fresno State #		
Dec. 27	vs. North Texas #	L	47-49		#Projected Flex Opponent		*Per Rivals
#New Mexico Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Sean Lewis • Record at School: 12-13 (2 years)			
				Career Record: 36-44 (7 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Matt Johnson			
				Defensive Coordinator: Demetrius Sumler • Location: San Diego, Calif.			
				Stadium: Snapdragon Stadium (35,000)			



LUCKY SUTTON

SCOUTING THE AZTECS

"I think that [head coach] Sean Lewis has done an excellent job there. They built that new stadium a few years ago, and I think that they're really gung-ho with really wanting to be good in football. That new stadium just makes it a lot more attractive for kids to go there. ... Sean has the ability to win there. Losing [defensive coordinator Rob Aurich to Nebraska] is tough, but they can get good players at San Diego State. They always have. I think now having the facilities that they have should keep that program on the rise."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	2	JORDAN NAPIER (JR.)	13	Nathan Acevedo (Sr.)
WR	17	JACOB BOSTICK (SR.)	14	DONOVAN BROWN (SR.)
WR	5	Bert Emanuel Jr. (Sr.)	18	Justus Lowe* (Sr.)
LT	78	JOSEPH BORJON (SR.)	77	Cam May (Sr.)
LG	76	KALAN ELLIS (SR.)	73	Evan Lawrence* (So.)
C	55	Michael Leville Watkins (So.)	63	Isaac Lucas (Jr.)
RG	67	Matthew Montgomery* (Jr.)	69	Alex Bleszynski (Fr.)
RT	65	Dennis Jones* (Sr.)	70	Mercer Luniewski* (So.)
TE	15	Jackson Ford (Jr.)	88	Ryan Wolfer (So.)
QB	4	JAYDEN DENEGAL (SR.)	12	Stone Saunders* (So.)
RB	7	LUCKY SUTTON (SR.)	21	Javion Kinnard* (So.)

DEFENSE (3)

EDGE	33	Brady Nassar (Sr.)	10	Lucan Amituanai (Fr.)
DT	11	Krishna Clay (Sr.)	48	Kainoa Davis (So.)
DT	18	MALACHI FINAU (SR.)	91	Amari Comier* (Sr.)
EDGE	97	Nate Henrich* (Jr.)	40	Charlie Stewart (Sr.)
LB	21	TANO LETULI (SR.)	31	Jeremiah Lewis* (So.)
LB	56	Sione Hala* (Sr.)	42	Cameron Cooper* (Jr.)
CB	83	Jamison Starks (So.)	32	Caleb Ricks* (So.)
CB	27	Mike Lindsay* (So.)	43	Braylon Cardwell (Fr.)
S	9	DALESEAN STALEY (SR.)	13	Prince Williams (So.)
S	24	Josiah Cox (Sr.)	20	Jelani McLaughlin (Jr.)
S	29	Josh Hunter (Sr.)	36	Isaiah Green* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	18	Nick Clegg (So.)	KR	20	Christian Washington (Sr.)
P	89	Tashi Dorje (Sr.)	PR	21	Javion Kinnard* (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

DAVID FRERKER-IMAGN IMAGES



BRAD JACKSON

SCOUTING THE BOBCATS

"Everybody thinks that [head coach] GJ Kinne is an excellent young coach who's doing a good job there, and he's had excellent offenses, so I know that he's well respected. As far as playing complementary football, can they control the clock in the last four minutes of a game and not give the ball back? There's nothing against playing fast and scoring, but it's just about if you have to slow it down and keep the clock running. If they can do that, they'll be able to be a good football team. ... People are really high on [Kinne] from what I've seen. That's a team that's returning a lot of talent. We definitely have eyes on them. It's a huge testament to him. He's done a great job there."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	11	BEAU SPARKS (SR.)	La'Keyleon Graves (Fr.)
WR	1	CHRIS DAWN JR. (SR.)	2 Kylen Evans (So.)
WR		Zechariah Sample* (So.)	Dameon Crowe (Fr.)
LT	68	SULLY BURNS (SR.)	Jaylen Early* (Sr.)
LG	53	Cameron Schultz (Jr.)	72 Kirk Gildon (Fr.)
C	66	Justin DeLeon (Jr.)	70 Ameer Ross (Fr.)
RG	75	Bamidele Badusi (Jr.)	55 Etueni Ropati (Jr.)
RT		Rasheed Jackson* (Jr.)	William Boone* (Jr.)
TE	16	BLAKE SMITH (SR.)	18 Ty Stamey (Jr.)
QB	8	BRAD JACKSON (SO.)	17 Gavin Parkhurst (Fr.)
RB	5	Jaylen Jenkins (Sr.)	4 Torrance Burgess Jr. (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	6	Jo'Laison Landry (Jr.)	33 Blake Isbell (Fr.)
DT		Tae Woody* (Sr.)	Phillip Bradford* (Jr.)
DT	96	BRYCE CARTER (SR.)	91 J.P. Deeter (Jr.)
EDGE	15	DonTerry Russell (Sr.)	35 Ta'Derius Collins (Jr.)
ILB	16	Terrence Cooks II (Sr.)	46 AYDEN JONES (JR.)
ILB		Javante Mackey* (Jr.)	45 Cole Nilles (Jr.)
CB	18	Craig Royal Jr. (Sr.)	27 Cordarian Powell (Fr.)
CB	24	Trez Moore (Sr.)	17 Christopher Jones (So.)
NB	22	Will Mitchell II (So.)	23 AMARION ATWOOD (JR.)
S	7	RYAN NOLAN (SR.)	26 Chase Davis (Jr.)
S	14	Jayden Bradley (Fr.)	37 Jayden Lawton (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K		Dylan Cunanan* (Jr.)	KR	5	Jaylen Jenkins (Sr.)
P		Thomas Flintoff* (Fr.)	PR	11	Beau Sparks (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



TEXAS STATE BOBCATS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 93 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 3-5 SUN BELT

OFFENSE Head coach GJ Kinne has lived up to his promise to "light up the scoreboard" since he arrived at Texas State in 2022. The Bobcats have led the Sun Belt Conference in total yards and finished at least second in scoring in each of the past three seasons.

As Texas State joins the revived Pac-12 Conference, Kinne will finally have the same starter behind center for consecutive seasons. Sophomore Brad Jackson returns after throwing for 3,224 yards and 21 touchdowns and rushing for 744 yards and 17 scores.

The Bobcats were the only FBS program with two 1,000-yard receivers in 2025 — Beau Sparks (1,200) and Chris Dawn Jr. (1,007) — and both are returning as seniors. With their most impactful contributors returning, the Bobcats will be in the end zone often.

DEFENSE As exciting as Texas State's offense has been under Kinne, the defense has been a point of aggravation. Late-game mistakes and an inability to hold on to leads led to offseason changes.

South Alabama defensive coordinator Will Windham, who promises to bring multiple looks and a more disciplined attitude, replaces two-year defensive coordinator Dexter McCoil.

The retention rate isn't as high on defense as it is on offense, but Windham will have the services of three of the Bobcats' top six tacklers from 2025 — senior safety Ryan Nolan (79) and senior linebackers Ayden Jones (56) and Terrence Cooks II (36).

SPECIALISTS Texas State's past two kickers transferred to power programs following strong seasons — Mason Shipley to Texas after 2024 and Tyler Robles to Washington last season. Toledo transfer Dylan Cunanan hopes to replicate their success after making 23-of-32 (72%) field-goal attempts the past two seasons. Australian freshman Thomas Flintoff takes over the punting duties. Jaylen Jenkins returns for his senior season after leading the Sun Belt in yards per kickoff return (27.0) in 2025, including a 100-yard touchdown against South Alabama.

FINAL ANALYSIS Texas State is averaging 36.5 points per game the past three seasons under Kinne and is returning nearly all of its skill-position players on offense. But Texas State can't truly contend on offense alone, or it would have done so already. Final records of 8-5 in 2023, 8-5 in 2024 and 7-6 in 2025 prove that a potent offense can net a winning record, but an undisciplined defense will prevent any contention for a conference championship. If the changes made on defense work, the Bobcats will compete for a Pac-12 championship in 2026.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 3-5 SUN BELT)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Eastern Michigan	W	52-27	Sept. 5	at Texas	1. Cullen Thompson, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 6	at UTSA	W	43-36	Sept. 12	UTSA	2. Lakeyleon Graves, ATH	★★★
Sept. 13	at Arizona State	L	15-34	Sept. 19	North Texas	3. Xavier Warren, WR	★★★
Sept. 20	Nicholls	W	35-3	Sept. 26	Incarmate Word	4. Easton Webb, QB	★★★
Oct. 3	at San Diego State			Oct. 3	at San Diego State	5. Jayden Luckett, OT	★★★
Oct. 4	at Arkansas State	L	30-31	Oct. 17	Colorado State	6. Devin Davis, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 11	Troy (ot)	L	41-48	Oct. 24	Utah State	7. Blake McLane, WR	★★★
Oct. 18	at Marshall (ot)	L	37-40	Oct. 31	at Boise State	8. Dameon Crowe, WR	★★★
Oct. 28	James Madison	L	20-52	Nov. 7	at Oregon State	9. Juntavious Harris, RB	★★★
Nov. 8	at Louisiana	L	39-42	Nov. 14	Fresno State	10. Jayden Flournoy, CB	★★★
Nov. 15	at Southern Miss	W	41-14	Nov. 21	Washington State		
Nov. 22	ULM	W	31-14	Nov. 28	at Colorado State #		
Nov. 29	South Alabama	W	49-26		#Projected Flex Opponent		*Per Rivals
Jan. 2	vs. Rice #	W	41-10				
			#Armed Forces Bowl				
TEAM INFORMATION							
Head Coach: GJ Kinne • Record at School: 23-16 (3 years) • Career Record: 35-18 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinators: Landon Keopple, Jordan Shoemaker • Defensive Coordinators: Will Windham, Matthew Gregg • Location: San Marcos, Texas • Stadium: UFCU Stadium (27,149)							



UTAH STATE AGGIES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 92 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 6-7, 4-4 MWC

OFFENSE The Aggies are likely turning to a familiar face to orchestrate the offense. Quarterback McCae Hillstead has transferred back to Utah State after two seasons at BYU. The junior played a lot as a true freshman for the Aggies and threw for 399 yards at home against James Madison.

USU lost two solid performers at wide receiver but does return Swiss Army knife Anthony Garcia, who produced seven touchdowns in 2025. The Aggies have brought in Eli Wood, who finished strong last season at Virginia, and slot target Javon Robinson (Georgia State) from the transfer portal to shore up that position. Robinson caught 58 passes a year ago.

The Aggies, who averaged 30.9 points and 409.5 total yards last season, return a proven commodity in running back Javen Jacobs, who accounted for 1,058 all-purpose yards and eight TDs as a junior.

USU head coach Bronco Mendenhall has brought in a familiar face at offensive coordinator in Robert Anae, who has worked with Mendenhall for 15 seasons, to replace Kevin McGiven, who departed to Utah.

DEFENSE There is some continuity on defense for the Aggies, who will need to improve on that side of the ball after allowing 440.1 yards — last in the Mountain West — and 28.7 points per outing last season.

Defensive coordinator Nick Howell is back, and the Aggies also returned a pair of honorable mention All-Mountain West honorees in safety Brevin Hamblin and linebacker Bronson Olevao Jr. The other three returning starters are defensive linemen Tyree Morris and Carson Tujague and linebacker Chris Joe.

The Aggies have brought in some notable athletes from the portal, highlighted by safety Chapman Lewis and cornerback Antonio Bluiett, who was an honorable mention FCS All-American at North Dakota last fall. Lewis started at Texas Tech in 2024.

SPECIALISTS USU has a new kicker in Kian Afrookhteh, who was an honorable mention All-Sun Belt performer last year at Coastal Carolina. USU returns punter Landon Rehkow, who averaged 42.9 yards per punt. The Aggies have a proven commodity at long-snapper in 2024 freshman All-American Hyrum Hatch. Jacobs is a weapon on returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Aggies, who went 6-7 during Mendenhall's first season at the helm, will play two power-conference opponents on the road — just like they did last season — in Washington and Utah. USU will likely have to face Boise State twice in '26. Making a return trip to a bowl game will be a challenge. USU beat only one opponent that went bowling a season ago and will likely need to defeat three 2025 bowl teams.

2025 RESULTS (6-7, 4-4 MWC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	UTEP	W	28-16	Sept. 5	Idaho State	1. Viliami Tapa'atoutai, EDGE	★ ★ ★
Sept. 6	at Texas A&M	L	22-44	Sept. 12	at Washington	2. Brody Flores, LB	★ ★
Sept. 13	Air Force	W	49-30	Sept. 19	at Utah	3. Dontae Dyson, CB	★ ★ ★
Sept. 20	McNeese	W	48-7	Sept. 26	Troy	4. John McClellan, LB	★ ★ ★
Sept. 27	at Vanderbilt	L	35-55	Oct. 3	at Boise State	5. Tripp Palmer, ATH	★ ★ ★
Oct. 11	at Hawai'i	L	26-44	Oct. 10	Washington State	6. Kaina Watson, WR	★ ★ ★
Oct. 17	San José State	W	30-25	Oct. 24	at Texas State	7. Brady Goodman, QB	★ ★ ★
Oct. 25	at New Mexico	L	14-33	Oct. 31	Colorado State	8. Cade McCall, WR	★ ★ ★
Nov. 8	Nevada	W	51-14	Nov. 7	Fresno State	9. Kaleb Maryland, QB	★ ★ ★
Nov. 15	at UNLV (ot)	L	26-29	Nov. 14	at San Diego State	10. Luke Baker, OT	★ ★ ★
Nov. 22	at Fresno State	W	28-17	Nov. 21	at Oregon State		
Nov. 28	Boise State	L	24-25	Nov. 28	Boise State #		
Dec. 22	vs. Washington State #L	21-34			#Projected Flex Opponent		*Per Rivals
#Famous Idaho Potato Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Bronco Mendenhall • Record at School: 6-7 (1 year)			
				Career Record: 146-95 (19 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Robert Anae			
				Defensive Coordinator: Nick Howell • Location: Logan, Utah			
				Stadium: Maverik Stadium (25,513)			



JAVEN JACOBS

SCOUTING THE AGGIES

"They got better and better over the course of last season. Effort, awareness, instincts. They didn't lose a ton. It's pretty clear that they're gonna have an advantage with continuity compared to some of the other teams in our conference. From the outside looking in, their coaching staff does a good job of being efficient with the resources that they have. ... The 3-3-5 defense is excellent, but people have been running it for a while. If you watch 3-3-5 teams, those coaches have kind of changed what they're doing because people kind of figured it out. But [head coach] Bronco Mendenhall is a heck of a coach, and I know he'll figure out what he needs to do to have a good defense."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	10	Anthony Garcia (Jr.)	Rex Haynes* (Jr.)
WR	6	Demick Starling (Sr.)	Eli Wood* (Sr.)
WR		Javon Robinson* (Sr.)	LJ Johnson Jr.* (So.)
LT		John Randle Jr.* (So.)	Chewy Wade* (So.)
LG	72	GEORGE MAILE (SR.)	Kadin Lynch* (Sr.)
C	55	JIMMY LISTON (JR.)	63 Jarvis Griffiths (Jr.)
RG	65	TAVO MOTU'APUAKA (SR.)	61 K'leyone Iosua (Jr.)
RT		Seth Wilfred* (Jr.)	54 Jackson Nelson (So.)
TE	18	Kache Kaio (Jr.)	Collin Remenowsky* (Sr.)
QB		McCae Hillstead* (Jr.)	Grady Brosterhous* (Sr.)
RB	8	JAVEN JACOBS (SR.)	23 Noah White (So.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	28	CARSON TUJAGUE (SO.)	Adonis Jackson* (Sr.)
NT		Ta'avili Tuitama* (Sr.)	92 Joshua Papu (So.)
DE	9	TYREE MORRIS (SR.)	Kasen Long* (So.)
BUCK	14	BRONSON OLEVAO JR. (SR.)	Asher Cunningham* (Jr.)
SLB	25	CHRIS JOE (SO.)	17 Mataira Brown (Jr.)
MLB		Harrison Taggart* (Sr.)	31 Dakota Howell (So.)
WLB		James Jennette* (Sr.)	Jeremiah Holmes* (Sr.)
CB		Antonio Bluiett* (Sr.)	15 D'Angelo Mayes (Jr.)
CB		Markie Grant* (So.)	38 John Shepard (Jr.)
NB	12	Bobby Arnold (Sr.)	27 Chika Ebonoha (Sr.)
BS	4	BREVIN HAMBLIN (SR.)	32 Charger Doty (So.)
FS		Chapman Lewis* (Jr.)	26 D'Andre Barnes (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K		Kian Afrookhteh* (Sr.)	KR	23	Noah White (So.)
P	19	Landon Rehkow (Jr.)	PR	8	Javen Jacobs (Sr.)

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TONY FREEMAN

SCOUTING THE COUGARS

"I thought that they made a couple of pretty good adds, but they just lost so many guys. I think it'll take some time with them. I actually think how they're recruiting right now, with how we evaluate that, they graded pretty highly. They struck me as a team that did pretty well trying to build in the portal. It's just so tough when you lose so many pieces. ... Oregon State and Washington State had a really nice advantage over the rest of the conference as being two teams that were real Pac-12 teams before this shift. They have resources that pretty much all the other teams in the Pac-12 who are coming from the Mountain West need to try to get to their level. I haven't seen anybody talking about that, but I think about it all the time."

— An opposing Pac-12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	0	TONY FREEMAN (SR.)	8	Branden Ganashamoorthy (Jr.)
WR	1	Daniel Blood* (Sr.)	13	Ryan McKendry* (So.)
WR	10	Tank Hawkins* (So.)	4	Darrius Clemons* (Sr.)
LT	71	ASHTON TRIPP (JR.)	54	Xavier Thorpe (So.)
LG	67	JONNY LESTER (SR.)	68	Chris Lino (So.)
C	69	Kyle Martin (Jr.)	55	Arion Williams (Fr.)
RG	75	Noah Dunham (Jr.)	77	Nick Bakken (So.)
RT	74	Maximus McCree* (Sr.)	64	Jaylin Caldwell (Sr.)
TE	23	TREY LECKNER (JR.)	28	Jack Pedersen* (Sr.)
QB	12	Caden Pinnick* (So.)	17	Owen Eshelman (Fr.)
RB	9	KIRBY VORHEES (JR.)	3	Maxwell Woods (So.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	9	Matyus McLain* (Jr.)	51	Ben Beatty (So.)
DT	52	Kaden Beatty (Jr.)	98	Jirah Leaupepetele* (Jr.)
DT	34	Damarjhe Lewis* (Sr.)	99	Paul Hutson III* (Sr.)
DE	6	Linus Zunk* (Sr.)	5	Michael Hughes (Jr.)
LB	21	Keith Brown (Sr.)	16	Isaiah Hung (Fr.)
LB	15	DJ Warner* (Jr.)	29	Erimus Wright (Fr.)
LB	8	Nylan Brown* (Jr.)	33	Gage Jones (So.)
CB	22	Jalil Tucker* (Sr.)	2	Jamarey Smith (Fr.)
CB	13	Khamari Terrell* (Sr.)	23	Ishmael Gibbs (Fr.)
SS	3	Jaylen Thomas* (So.)	19	Kayo Patu (So.)
FS	1	Jeremiah Bernard* (Jr.)	17	Jshawn Frausto-Ramos* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	38	Jack Stevens (So.)	KR	10	Tank Hawkins* (So.)
P	32	Max Dean* (So.)	PR	0	Tony Freeman (Sr.)

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WASHINGTON STATE COUGARS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 88 | PAC-12 PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6

OFFENSE In 2026, Washington State's offense could shift back to the high-flying approach that fans across the country have come to recognize. But many of the faces behind the operation will be new. WSU's quarterback could be rising redshirt sophomore Caden Pinnick, a transfer from FCS UC Davis, where he put up gaudy numbers and won the Big Sky Freshman of the Year award. Or it could be returner Owen Eshelman, a redshirt freshman, who has also impressed during spring practices.

The good news for the Cougars is that no matter who starts, he'll have some experienced teammates around him. WSU returns a number of experienced offensive linemen — left tackle Ashton Tripp, left guard Jonny Lester, center Kyle Martin, right guard Noah Dunham, right tackle Jaylin Caldwell — plus a transfer in veteran Maximus McCree. That group will help carve out lanes for the running back trio of Kirby Vorhees, Maxwell Woods and Leo Pulalasi, who combined for 212 carries for 1,006 yards and five touchdowns last season, the majority coming from Vorhees.

DEFENSE The Cougars' defense will likely sink or swim based on the performance of the line. They lost a lot at that position over the offseason, including six key players who followed former head coach Jimmy Rogers to Iowa State, but they may have replaced much of that production via the transfer portal.

WSU can likely count on a consistent pass rush from ends Matyus McLain (42 tackles, 13.5 for a loss, 4.5 sacks, one forced fumble at FCS Idaho last year) and Linus Zunk (15 tackles, 3.5 for a loss, three sacks at Vanderbilt last year), but the Cougars have less experience on the interior. They will roll out a combination of Kaden Beatty, Purdue transfer Damarjhe Lewis, Marshall transfer Paul Hutson III and FCS Eastern Washington transfer Jirah Leaupepetele.

SPECIALISTS Kicker Jack Stevens is back after his WSU debut season last fall, when he connected on 16-of-19 field goals and made all 33 of his extra points. Punter Max Dean, a transfer from New Mexico State, totaled 55 punts for an average of 42.3 yards for the Aggies last season. Look for Florida transfer wideout Tank Hawkins to return kickoffs and/or punts.

FINAL ANALYSIS After another offseason of big roster turnover at WSU, the Cougars' offense will look more familiar. In the first year of the rebuilt Pac-12, new head coach Kirby Moore will guide an offense replete with talent, even if there are some unanswered questions at the QB spot. Depending on how the Cougs' defense fares, this team could compete for a high finish in the new conference.

2025 RESULTS (7-6)

Aug. 30	Idaho	W	13-10
Sept. 6	San Diego State	W	36-13
Sept. 13	at North Texas	L	10-59
Sept. 20	Washington	L	24-59
Sept. 27	at Colorado State	W	20-3
Oct. 11	at Ole Miss	L	21-24
Oct. 18	at Virginia	L	20-22
Oct. 25	Toledo	W	28-7
Nov. 1	at Oregon State	L	7-10
Nov. 15	Louisiana Tech	W	28-3
Nov. 22	at James Madison	L	20-24
Nov. 29	Oregon State	W	32-8
Dec. 22	vs. Utah State #	W	34-21

#Famous Idaho Potato Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Washington
Sept. 12	at Kansas State
Sept. 19	Duquesne
Sept. 26	Arizona
Oct. 3	Fresno State
Oct. 10	at Utah State
Oct. 17	at Oregon State
Oct. 24	Boise State
Oct. 31	at San Diego State
Nov. 14	Colorado State
Nov. 21	at Texas State
Nov. 28	Oregon State #

#Projected Flex Opponent

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Ryan McKendry, WR	★★★
2. Nathaniel Salmon, TE	★★★
3. Lance McGee, LB	★★★
4. Tremayne Hill, RB	★★★
5. CJ Toney, RB	★★★
6. JaVon Joseph, EDGE	★★★
7. Bryce Heckard, CB	★★★
8. Cooper Daines, IOL	★★★
9. Bryson Flynn, LB	★★★
10. Elmo Wartson, CB	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Kirby Moore • Record at School: First Season
Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinator: Matt Miller
Defensive Coordinator: Trent Bray • Location: Pullman, Wash.
Stadium: Martin Stadium (32,952)